

5.3 Instant Messaging



Stay in touch with Windows Messenger

Instant messaging refers to electronic communication (using text, voice, and video) over the Internet between two or more users who are all online at the same time. Instant messaging is online communication in contrast to e-mail which is, in effect, a method of offline communication since the recipient of an e-mail does not need to be online to read it. Instant messaging has revolutionised the way we communicate with friends, family and co-workers.

Imagine wishing your daughter happy birthday in real-time when you are away on a business trip at a fraction of the cost of a telephone call. Or communicating simultaneously in real-time with your colleagues based in different cities to discuss the new project. Sure, this is possible with call conferencing as well, but nothing can match the convenience and affordability of instant messaging.

Windows XP comes with an instant messaging tool called Windows Messenger that lets you do the above, and more! The following are some of the key features offered by Windows Messenger apart from instant text messaging:

Voice conversation: Windows Messenger allows you to have clear voice conversations over the Internet with your contacts.

Video conversation: If you have a Web camera installed, you can have video conversations.

File transfer: You can transfer files such as documents and photos directly in real-time without leaving Windows Messenger.